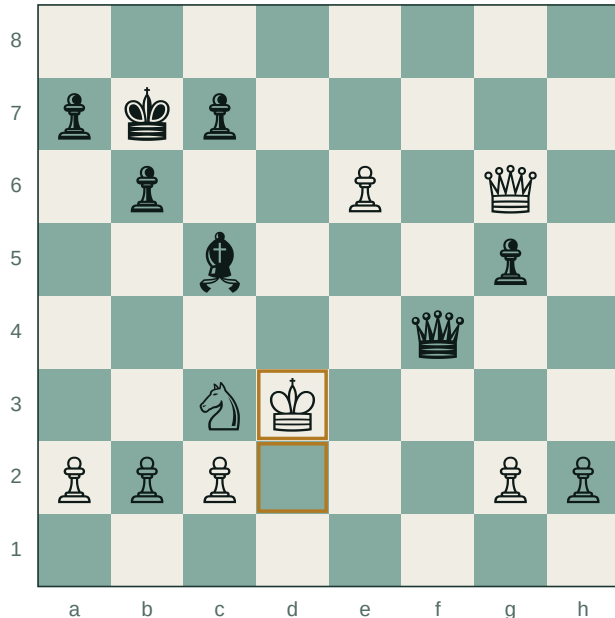


Exposed-king tactics: Black, move 39

Exposed-king tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Kd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Qe3+ 40. Kc4 Qd4+ 41. Kb3 Qb4#

39...Qe3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **40.Kc4**.

40...Qd4+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on c4 and knight on c3. Recorded reply: **41.Kb3**.

41...Qb4# Mate: queen on b4 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b3. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on b4. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on d3. Geometrically undefended: queen on g6. Check for tactical protection.